Audition

By Jane Martin

An actress in her late twenties runs up on the stage. She is nervous. She shields her eyes against the light. She is dressed in a slightly bizarre and trendy style. She carries in her arms a cat on a leash.

INTRODUCTION

In the early stages of her career, when Barbra Streisand was an unknown and hadn't yet become world-famous, she went to an audition very visibly chewing a large wad of gum. Called to the stage, she chomped on the gum, started to sing a few notes, then stopped and with an abashed and very charming smile she took the chunk of gum out of her mouth and stuck it under a stool seat. Then she sang her songs.

Later, after all auditions were completed and performers had left, a curious director went to the stool and looked at the underside. No chewing gum. Streisand had faked the whole thing.

Why? "The girl who was chewing gum" stood out from all the others. You have to smile and shake your head at that...and remember her forever thereafter.

That may or may not be a true story . . . but it is true that auditions involve many things, including mind games and cunning strategy. No, these "tricks" won't replace careful preparation and talent, but in a highly competitive world, one seeks whatever advantages one can devise.

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ACTRESS: Hi. Hey Hi. Wow. All Right. Nice place. Nice, uh, nice theatre. Good vibes. Yowsa me yessiree. Toy boat, toy boat, toy boat, toy boat. Now . . . let's see here. For my . . . can you hear me? Can you? No? Yes? You are out there, right? *(She puts the cat on the floor, her foot on the leash)* O.K., so we're all here. Well, I mean, you're ***there*** and I'm ***here*** but we're all. . . forget it.

Let's see. . . Audition, RAH! Get that part! O.K., my ***name*** is. . . s***, I forgot my name. Right. This. . . this would be construed as craziness. My name is. . . I did, I forgot my name. . . my stage name. . . see I decided to use my new stage name for this audition. . . for uh, for luck, it was. . . it was very. . . look what d'you care right? My human, world name is Mary Titfer.

Titfer. You got it? Goodo! O.K., can you hear me? All the way back? Loud and clear Captain Marvel? A-O.K.!

. . . Now, one more introduction and we're under way. The uh, the small person on my leash is my cat 'Tat.' My cat, 'Tat.' Get it? *(Points to herself)* Titfer *(Points to cat)* Tat. Right, you got it. Hey, we're waking up here. We're demonstrating consciousness. O.K., O.K., now you. . . the imperial you. . . have a part. I, Titfer, need a part. We are thus in tune. Synchronicity. Soooooooo, it's audition city!

Now I've got two pieces for you today, and here's the surprise, I've got one classical piece. . . . late greats, and I've got one contemporary piece. . . dispatches from the front. Good. For my classical piece I will take off all my clothes . . . 'Crude Rube Protrudes Dubious Boobies.' Beep-Beep. O.K., O.K., but all kidding and joshing aside I will take them off. Now, why is this classical? Surely, you jest. The body, the body is classical. . . it goes all the way back. . . and all the way front. Har, har. It starts the art, the body does. But there's no argument there, eh? Naturally not. O.K., O.K., now in the great tradition of auditions you may stop me at anytime. You can stop me one second after I start. But, ***BUT***. . . and here is the stinger. . .

(She takes a hammer out of her purse, and a nail) Bear with me. O.K.? Little hyped-up. A simple task and I'll be back with you. *(She nails the cat's leash to the floor)* There. Tat the cat, that's that. Nice kitty. Where were we? Toy boat, toy boat, toy boat, toy boat. O.K., stop me at any time. Right, O.K. Just yell. 'Thank you Miss Tifter.' Firm but courteous and zaparoonie. . .I stop. I nip the strip. ***But*** when I stop my classical piece, I shift immediately into my contemporary piece, which is. . . full attention now. Beating the cat's head in with the hammer!

Yipes! Holy Mackeral! 'Is this broad kidding?' Wellllll, I wouldn't want to spoil it for you but I don't think she's kidding. So, dear listeners, that's the full menu. . . that's all she wrote. But the tickle in the tushy are the options.

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Option A . . . we will let this poor, desperate and deluded girl debase herself. . . and I would, will, be debased. . . mortified. . . I mean. . . ***no clothes***. . . here? In front of strangers? Crummy, yucky, hateful! Or. . .

Option B. . . we can yell out 'Thank you Miss Tifter' and watch her clonk the kitty. . . and remember, Miss Tifter is fast. It will happen in a flash. . . kittyplasm . . . and haven't we, you, 'fess up now' actually killed little puss? Responsibility!

Or Option C, the second-to-last option, we could give Mary Titfer the crummy, undemanding, twelve-line, two-scene part, which, let me assure you, any mildly competent average workday actress could do while standing on her head humming, 'You can take this job and shove it'. . . backwards.

O.K., last option. . . now this is just too tawdry but we are nothing if not thorough. We could give her the part ***now***, and then when she splits, she and the furry hostage, we could take it away from her on the basis that she needs. . . shhh, psychiatric attention. But if you did that. . . if you did ***that***, Mary Tifter would find you and Jacobean revenge, kill the feline, and, perhaps -- disturbing thought -- herself in a particularly garish and oriental manner RIGHT IN FRONT OF YOU. Now she might not have nerve but on the other hand we don't know. We just don't know.

O.K., O.K. We're ready to go in the wooden O. We're out of the exposition and into the meat of the matter. Denouement. Everybody has their work cut out for them. The dialectic. You have a part. I want a part. We have serious business here. Right? Right. I will begin my classical piece. Watch me closely, both my hands are connected to my arms *(She begins to unbutton her blouse as the lights fade out)*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jane Martin
Book: Talking With
ISBN: 978-0573630217
Publisher: Samuel French, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): April 1983

AWARDS

MN State Qualifier
UT State Qualifier

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